

Plants for tropical gardens

Brightly-colored flowers and lush foliage create a tropical theme. While some plants hail from hot countries, many hardy types also create the look.

Choose plants with very large leaves that lend a sculptural quality to your designs. In cool climates, plant a backdrop of hardier foliage plants, such as hosta, bamboo, and ferns, and inject color in summer with a range of exotic-looking flowers. Dahlia, ginger lily, honeybush, and canna will survive mild winters if covered with a deep mulch of shredded bark or leaves—or simply bring the plants indoors if your climate is too cold. Likewise, many species of pineapple lily will survive outside in a pot, if turned on side to keep the soil dry and placed in a sheltered area.



PERENNIAL LARGE

Agapanthus Headbourne hybrids

AFRICAN LILY A perennial with arching, straplike leaves and blue funnel-shaped flowers from late summer to early fall. Plant near the front of a bed. In cold areas, mulch with organic matter; remove spent blooms.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀ Z6–9



PERENNIAL LARGE

Agave americana

CENTURY PLANT An evergreen perennial with sharply pointed, lance-shaped, cream-edged gray-green leaves. In hot summers, cream flowers appear atop tall stems. Grow in a container in cold areas and overwinter the plant indoors.

↑↔ up to 5ft (1.5m)

☀ Z9–11 ☹



PERENNIAL SMALL

Begonia 'Escargot'

BEGONIA An evergreen perennial, this variety bears spiral-shaped, purple-tinted green leaves with swirly silver markings and small pink flowers in fall. Grow as a houseplant in winter and bring outdoors in a pot during summer.

↑10in (25cm) ↔20in (50cm)

☀ Z10–11



SHRUB LARGE

Brugmansia x candida

ANGELS' TRUMPETS An evergreen shrub or small tree with oval green leaves and, from summer to fall, large exotic-looking trumpet-shaped night-scented blooms. 'Grand Marnier' (above) has apricot blooms. Protect it from frost.

↑15ft (5m) ↔8ft (2.5m)

☀ ☹ Z11



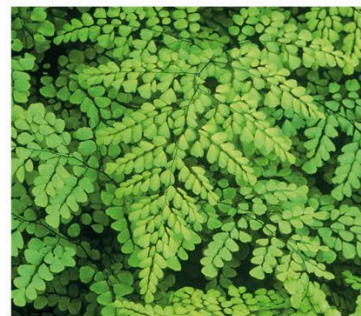
SHRUB MEDIUM

Abutilon 'Kentish Belle'

FLOWERING-MAPLE This shrub, semievergreen in warm areas, bears small triangular leaves and orange and red, bell-shaped summer blooms. Plant it close to a sunny wall or use it as a screen to lend a tropical flavor to a sheltered garden.

↑↔ 8ft (2.5m)

☀ ☹ Z9–11



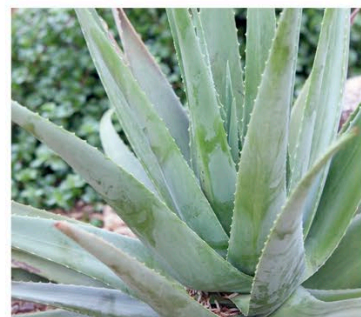
PERENNIAL SMALL

Adiantum venustum

HIMALAYAN MAIDENHAIR FERN This deciduous fern, evergreen in mild areas, has triangular fronds, rusty brown in fall and winter, divided into fan-shaped segments. Plant in a shady area with contrasting foliage plants, such as coleus.

↑9in (23cm) ↔12in (30cm)

☀ ☹ Z5–8



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Aloe vera

ALOE An evergreen perennial with fleshy, spine-edged gray-green leaves. It is often grown as a house plant in cold areas, but makes an exotic contribution to sunny summer gardens when grown in a pot; overwinter it indoors.

↑24in (60cm) ↔indefinite

☀ ☹ Z10–11



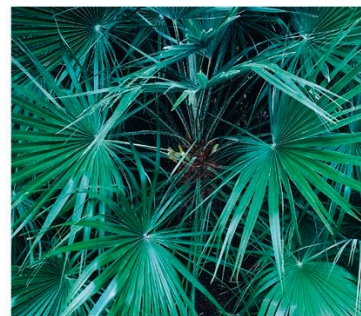
PERENNIAL LARGE

Canna 'Wyoming'

CANNA This perennial has paddle-shaped purple-bronze leaves and, from midsummer to early fall, pale orange gladioluslike flowers. Yellow, orange, or red blooms with colorful foliage are also available. Lift the rhizomes and overwinter indoors.

↑6ft (1.8m) ↔20in (50cm)

☀ ☹ Z8–11



SHRUB LARGE

Chamaerops humilis

EUROPEAN FAN PALM This compact evergreen palm has fan-shaped, divided green leaves. Mature plants bear clusters of small yellow summer flowers. Relatively hardy, it lends an exotic look to sheltered tropical-style gardens.

↑10ft (3m) ↔6ft (2m)

☀ ☹ Z8–11